
Lindsey Graham Finally Got What He Wanted

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South Carolina Sen. Lindsey Graham has a hard-earned skip in his step. After nearly a decade of obsequious, showy servility to the president he [once warned](#) would be the death knell of the Republican Party, Graham is getting what he wants: an interventionist Republican president merrily drawing up a list of baddies to take down, starting with captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro.

Graham was one of the first to recognize, long ago, that Donald Trump's policy views are determined mostly by the flattery of the last person to speak with him before a decision. For both of Trump's presidencies, Graham has worked to flatter Trump at every turn, and to be the final person to do so. While Graham has his hands in a lot of policy jars, his passion is an interventionist foreign policy. That's led to an ever-running proxy battle for Trump's sympathies between himself and an ascendant noninterventionist "America First" foreign policy wing, as best represented in the Senate by Kentucky's Rand Paul.

Graham couldn't contain his glee on Sunday aboard *Air Force One* as he stood inches from Trump, shortly after the Venezuela operation.

The president was rattling through a list of countries in the Americas that would go down next. Mexico? "You have to do something with Mexico." What about a mission in Colombia? "It sounds good to me." And as for the big, bad hemispheric archnemesis of 70 years Cuba: "Looks like it's ready for fall."

"Yes!" Graham said, beaming with the glow of someone whose life had been leading to this very moment.

JUST IN - President Trump: "Cuba is ready to fall." pic.twitter.com/f0pCC8YGsu

— Insider Paper (@TheInsiderPaper)
[January 5, 2026](#)

Aboard *Air Force One*, in his own remarks—which the [president frequently interrupted](#) with stray thoughts about how, for example, he would've taken out bin Laden before 9/11—Graham laid it on extra thick.

"We had Venezuela, we have Cuba, we have Colombia in our backyard. And these three countries have been condemned ever since I've been in politics," Graham said. "Joe Biden put a \$25 million bounty on Maduro's head." And "this commander in chief," he added, "he did something people *talked* about doing."

Graham isn't just thinking about the "backyard" (a whole hemisphere), though. Also on Sunday—the senator was everywhere on Sunday—he appeared on Fox News with a message for another, more distant regime that he has long believed in changing. And he brought a prop.

"I pray and hope that 2026 will be"—here he paused to put on a baseball cap bearing the slogan he

would then utter—"the year that we make Iran great again."

Graham: I pray and hope the 2026 will be *puts on hat* the year that we make Iran great again. pic.twitter.com/eHbM8bjGWY

— Acyn (@Acyn)
[January 5, 2026](#)

Graham has been waiting for a moment like this for a while, ever since the failures of the Iraq and Afghanistan wars soured the public on the wisdom of nation-building. For a long time, Graham hitched his wagon to the celebrity of his friend and fellow hawk John McCain. Since McCain's death, and with the rise of an isolationist element in the MAGA movement, Graham has been trying to work Trump in his direction. The kidnapping of one hostile foreign leader is, for Graham, a good start.

But not all is joyous in the Senate Republican conference. Just as much as Graham might sound as if he's won the long fight for Trump's foreign-policy orientation, Rand Paul is sounding as if he's lost.

Paul [reflected on Trump's tenure](#) Monday, speaking with reporters.

"Whenever I had misgivings about something else, I'd always come back and say, 'Well, he's the best we've ever had,' much better than the Bushes, who were war-mad and wanted to be involved in all these crazy wars overseas and were going to make the world safe for democracy—I never liked any of that," he said. "And I thought Trump was different. And so it disappoints me that he's under the thrall of Lindsey Graham.

"There should be a law," Paul continued, "that Lindsey Graham can only go to the White House every other week."

How much credit does Graham give himself for persuading Trump to move in a more interventionist direction? I asked Graham this on Tuesday. He was smart enough not to bite, awarding credit for all critical thinking to the president.

"I'm just reinforcing what he told me in January 2025," he said. "I had a talk with him. We have a drug caliphate in our backyard—look at it as a caliphate. Instead of complaining about it, let's get rid of it. These are not, you know, unbeatable foes. And I think the American people would appreciate somebody finally stopping those who are poisoning Americans and making billions of dollars." (Also: Get rid of Iran.)

Both Graham and Paul had throngs of reporters following them in the Capitol Tuesday, getting their sides of the long-running foreign-policy feud that had now swung dramatically in one direction. Paul was talking on the level of legality, and about how the administration's arguments that Maduro's capture was a law-enforcement operation, and thus not a military operation requiring congressional input, made no sense.

"If you say that we don't have to declare war because this is a criminal" case, he told reporters, "it would basically be an argument you could go to any country where you had a beef, that you could get an indictment for them" and run a military operation to decapitate the state.

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Rand Paul might have the law, but Lindsey Graham has Trump. I asked Graham if he felt that he had won the battle against Paul in favor of interventionism. Graham took issue with the term itself.

"This is not *intervention*," he said. "This is protecting America. It's not like 'Hey, what are you doing today? Let's go to Venezuela. Seems like nice beaches, good-looking people. Let's take it.' This is protecting America from threat."

"Rand Paul"—he paused for a second and ever so slightly rolled his eyes, considering his words—"doesn't believe that radical Islam is a threat. He would withdraw, he'd be America Fortress, America Fortress. There'd be no troops anywhere. Trump wants to protect the country.

"America First," he summed it up, "is taking countries that hurt America and change them. Interventionism is going somewhere without a real good reason."

That's his story, and he's sticking to it.

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